MPC FORMATION AND APPROACHES TO DE-MINING

In November 2012,the MPC was formed as a "national focal point for coordination, political negotiations, mine action and outreach" (MPC 2015; see Su Mon Thazin Aung, this volume), with mine action coordinated by the Myanmar Mine Action Centre operating under the auspices of the MPC. This brought a burst of international activity in mine action, mostly promoting de-mining efforts and mine risk education (LRC 2013; NPA 2013).The discussion of landmines focused on technical inputs for de-mining, including survey and risk education to enable greater access for humanitarian and development responses, for example, as part of durable solutions in Kachin State (HCT 2014).

These approaches, enacted before the NCA was signed, conjoined landmine removal with military and humanitarian security issues, and overlooked political imperatives at local levels. As Jacob (2014, p. 393) shows, such approaches reinforce a "security–development nexus" that prevents understanding of broader political contestations. They narrow the 'protection' of populations to a question of de-mining. The strong emphasis on de-mining unwittingly brought more attention to the military and strategic value of landmines for Myanmar's armed actors, leading to the view that ceasefires needed to be well in place before work on their removal begins (Myanmar Times 2014).

These approaches also overlooked crucial trust-building efforts needed to work with EAGs and their local populations (see Myanmar Peace Support Initiative 2013, p. 27). The situation was exacerbated by a perception among some EAGs that international organizations operating predominately from government areas into those administered by EAGs were being used as government proxies to reduce their administrative and military control over their own regions.[6] Landmine use by EAGs and communities could be said to prevent this from occurring. As a result, humanitarian mine action has been limited to risk education to raise awareness of the dangers of landmines.

These examples echo Jacob's warning for outsiders to be wary of "rushing in liberal governance reforms before reconciling the underlying conceptualizations and discourses of security and protection that are contested in existing political relationships" (2014, p. 402). Approaches to landmine contamination may be better undertaken with consideration to the nature of "political contestation"(Jacob 2014, p. 398) on the ground, and